

Book Review: Abroad in Japan

10 Years in the Land of the Rising Sun

TL;DR: For someone who enjoys slice-of-life content and finds British humor funny, the book is an easy thumbs up. Whether it's 4/5 or 5/5 depends on how interested you personally are in the non-viral parts of Japan.

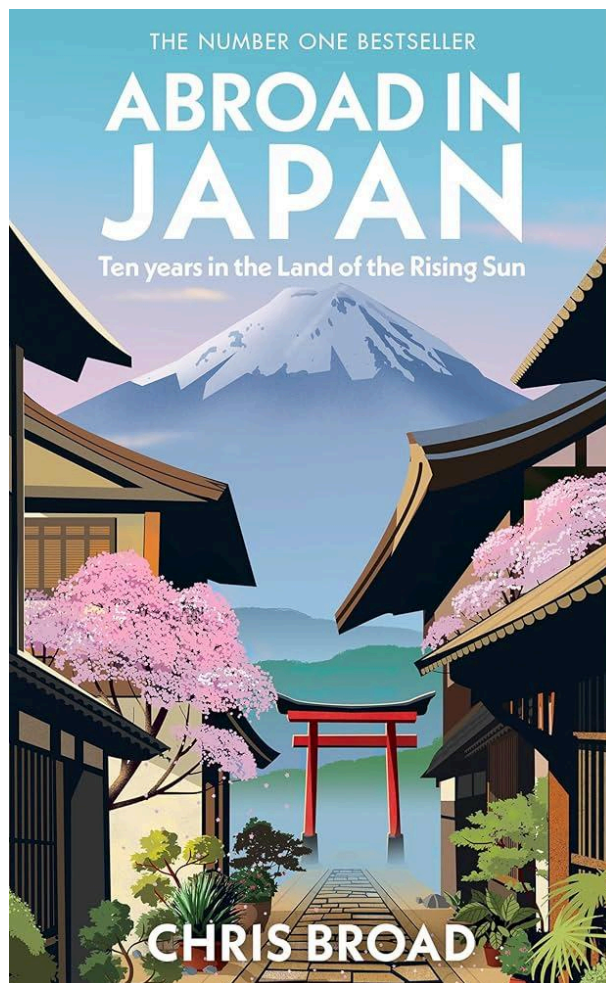
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How I found this book

In an incredibly shocking news flash, I do watch the occasional Youtube video on life in Japan and stumbled across the author's Youtube channel: Abroad in Japan. Yes I know it's also the title of the book and yes I also know that it's a good pun on his last name (a [Chris] Broad in Japan). Over time I ended up watching more of his videos and my favorite videos generally involve his collaborations with CDawgVA in Wacky Weekends or Food/Drink tasting vlogs. At some point I was watching a podcast where Chris Broad was using his book's popularity to banter with CDawgVA. At that time I only put a small mental pin at the thought of reading it and continued playing random Youtube videos. Fast forward to 2026 and with an e-ink phone I realized that reading his book was the most entertaining media I could consume so here we are...

The longer part of this review will first cover the major points that stuck with me months later. The comments and lessons will be after.



The Initial Landing



The first 3 videos on Abroad in Japan

The autobiography starts off with an acceptance letter into the Japan Exchange Teaching (JET) Program and how Chris found himself in this position right after graduating college. Apparently this initiative to ship himself across the globe was all from a quick talk with someone on an airplane. Yup. From there Chris got assigned to a small city called Sakata in the Yamagata prefecture which was a far cry from his expectations of Osaka, Tokyo, and even Kyoto. You'd think from the city location it'd be a pretty boring time but a majority of the book is dedicated to his time there. While a good chunk of the narrative was general culture shock and learning, a majority of his stories were about the bonds and experiences he had with the locals (which I also agree is worth talking about).

Right after landing in Japan he was quickly ushered around the JET onboarding process which basically had every minute lined out until the evening. In the evening Chris eventually found himself in a sushi restaurant at the Kabukicho district of Shinjuku trying to finish a bowl of fish guts - quite possibly the worst way to get British people introduced to the country's food. After that fun experience it was time for the goat to be shipped far away to a place where he becomes 1 of 3 foreigners in the entire town. One was a new JET teacher like Chris but the other one was considered a legendary teacher not just in JET but in Sakata as well. Rory not only had an insane Kanji vocabulary but he also managed to grind out teaching in Sakata for 5 years - a basically unheard of feat considering JET normally lasts 3 years. After the initial greetings, Rory took Chris and the other JET teacher to a few common spots around Sakata including the onsen, izakaya, and it was all done in a beaten down old car. While most of us couldn't fathom the difficulty of getting a car in the states, Chris had basically no luck and relied on Rory for 2 main reasons: 1 was that he made so little money that saving up for even a used car would take YEARS. 2 was that - unlike the other JET teacher - Chris was NOT lucky enough to get a free car. As a result he was reliant on Rory unless he wanted to walk/bike to his destination (He would eventually Rory's car after he left Sakata due to his JET program ending).

After some initial exploration Chris quickly found himself immersed with navigating both the students within all of his classes but also all of the Not-the not-always-fluent English teachers. While Chris' expectations were that he'd work as a TA it seemed like in Sakata he was likely the best English resource by a long shot. Once again I won't go over all of the hijinks that occur during the initial acclimating month but Chris would get invited to also be English speaker of the town - mostly for adults who never had the chance to learn enough in school. While the main motivation was food, it also served as another way for Chris to quickly adjust to his new life thousands of miles away. During one of these sessions Chris found himself registered for a Japanese speech competition where non-native folks were encouraged to talk about their experiences navigating this new world. In a bit of a foreshadowing maneuver, Chris decided to talk about fried chicken but despite his many attempts to write, repeat, and memorize - the speech never fully formed. The spectacular flubbing of his speech combined with the general inability to communicate with folks eventually had Chris studying hours before work in an effort to prove to the rest of Sakata that he wasn't just a bumbling foreigner.

The Remaining Years in the JET Program

This now transitions from the initial culture shock and experiences of living in a foreign country into the more nuanced cultural differences - the first of which he experiences is the level of bullying in schools. While it's a common plot point in various forms of media, having to witness it to the extreme as a 24 year old guy does NOT sound fun. Some slightly less depressing (but still not fun) cultural norms are the weaponization of your health reports. Not only does the entire company know that Chris has abnormal cholesterol levels but they're not afraid to voice it in every meal. (As a side note writing it out does kinda sound like the typical East Asian household experience but I swear it's cooked). Perhaps the most ironic part about the health comments is that throughout his first year in Japan Chris started studying Japanese an hour before work and many hours after work with coworkers and friends; as a result Chris would understand ALL of the directed comments about his eating habits 🌸. The last and most lighthearted cultural norm is called "omiyage" which is the practice of bringing EVERYONE souvenirs from your vacation. In a small scope this sounds really neat but in a school of 100+ teachers many of Chris' coworkers would just go on vacation while saying they are just "relaxing at home". With this tech Chris decided to finally venture



into one of the cities he initially pined for when applying to JET: Osaka. To keep this vacation short Chris enjoyed the city, had massive rizz, and got turbo grieved by xenophobia. After his vacation the JET days started flying by with some of the highlights being Chris' first long-term relationship in Japan, winning the Japanese foreigner speech competition with the help of his friends, and the coincidental meeting of a pivotal figure in Chris' career Natsuki. As his final days of the JET program approached Chris eventually found himself with the opportunity to abandon all the relationships he forged in Sakata and try to make a career out of his semi-viral Youtube channel in Sendai.

Transitioning from JET to Youtube

As a forewarning, I was less interested in these sections because a lot of the stories were actually directly related to videos Chris would end up creating. Interviewing locals impacted by the Fukushima disaster, covering the alleged grave of Christ (in Japan), reacting to an ICBM alarm that woke him up from a business trip - the list goes on and on but the main thing I wanted to point out was that Chris took his experience in Sakata and wanted to try to share those experiences with folks online. While he would still create your classic Tokyo/tourist videos, his most proud works always involved chatting with Is in spots that most tourists wouldn't even consider commuting through during a vacation. It was also during this era where Chris would get some levels of popularity and with the help of Natsuki and Ryotoro he eventually had a nice apartment and studio in Sendai. One other thing that Chris would discover during this period is how much of a GOAT Ken Watanabe is as a person. While Chris was familiar with his roles in various Western medias, his journeys across the coast revealed that Ken Watanabe was secretly sending money and aid towards folks impacted by the Fukushima tsunami and following the nuclear disaster. Students would get trumpets to keep practicing music, stores would be renovated with Ken's money, and himself would frequent the area as if he was a local. ThisWhile at the time Chris always joked about meeting Ken in the flesh, realizing that he had missed the legend by a week felt almost scripted - but not as scripted as his next and final arc of the novel.



Molding a Youtube Brand



One of my favorite videos from both an info and entertainment standpoint

At this point Chris has basically figured out what content motivates him but is also completely unexplored - exploring the charming local intricacies of various prefectures. And he was right. Journey Across Japan (including similar styled videos like Wacky Weekends) almost never cover the flashy tourist spots but instead weave a narrative surrounding the locals and Chris' personal snippets in an organic fashion. Eventually his work had built Chris a solid reputation - one so solid that Ryotaro pitched a meeting between Chris and Ken Watanabe. Ken's team said yes and suddenly Chris was no temporal distance as Ken was sitting in front of him. I could probably talk more about this interaction but I think it's safe to say that the brand Chris had built paid off in basically every possible way. He had the drive to weave stories of locals and their story with larger forces (eg. depopulation, governmental forces) with production levels and pacing that rival traditional documentaries. Once again, this part of his story is heavily covered and you can watch (or search up various videos of random prefectures and there will be a story (and maybe multiple videos) to go with it on his channel.

Final Thoughts

While I personally rate this book a 5/5 I am also the perfect audience member for his Youtube videos. In spite of that I cannot emphasize how much of a disservice I am doing by paraphrasing this book - if you've gotten this far in the blog I think you should at least check it out from a local library.

As for interesting lessons I think the main one is the narrative of just saying "Yes". Throughout most of his stories, the simple action of going "Why not?" and following along ended up giving him some of the greatest opportunities and experiences. This is in stark contrast to the narrative I've commonly seen online which is the power of saying "No" but digging a little deeper I think you can apply Chris' advice to basically any life experience outside of work. As for the power of saying "No"? Well I think there's a lot more nuance but I do think it's something that you can only rely on once

you can basically consider thousands of possibilities - likely a skill I won't have until I'm an unc.

While not explicitly stated I think Chris undersells his own creative vision since h you can still sense a trace of familiarity throughout each story since they're very similar to his videos. While it is true that he has written the book literally 10 years after he first landed I s it's undeniable that the actions and lessons he learned still have their mark in his videos - specifically covering smaller areas and giving them a chance to be in the spotlight. While you have to stretch your thinking a bit this ideology is a pretty cool sign of a good leader (at least in my opinion). While Chris doesn't really talk about how he is as a boss I imagine there's something to be said about giving everyone a chance to be the center stage and give their story with no bias to the big dogs like Tokyo.

Something else I want to highlight is just how out of touch Chris is with weeb/otaku culture as a result of his initial years in Japan .I don't even know if Anime was popular when he was in the UK but there are MANY clips where he's just dumbfounded by some of the Anime plots (as they're being explained to him by other Japan-centered Youtubers).

So as a final note if you want to read my chronological recollection of the book for this blog I'll put it down below. Otherwise have a GREAT high noon and I'll see you next time!

- The idea that in another world me or a friend would be in a tiny apartment in rural Japan still doesn't seem real but this book is proof that it's a path some people choose to follow.
- While I didn't really read the book with the intention of learning career advice it turns out
- Fun fact apparently the writing process was so brutal for him that it was the only thing he could think of in his free time and it was even brought up during various events like the Charity Cyclathon for the Immune Deficiency Foundation.
- Also he's apparently writing another book where he covers every single prefecture (think of US states) in Japan so whenever that book drops expect a book review soon after.
- I actually had heard of the JET program like a decade ago (holy unc) because an artist I followed on Twitter was actually wrapping up their JET tenureship and talked quite a bit about their experience online (lozyrosie: <https://twitter.com/lozyrosie>).
- It's also REALLY funny how he got nerd sniped by a random person on a plane 😭.
- Also incredible how fast-paced the JET program orientation sounded since you kinda get hit with information overload and then shipped to your designated

school. Doesn't help that this guy decided to go to the seedy area of Shinjuku and hammered some like raw fish soup thing.

- The memory trick he used (assigning coworker names to English actions) really does sound Mickey Mouse but the results speak for themselves.
- I've heard of Mind Palace and seeing it used for a speech was pretty awesome. I don't think I could EVER recite a speech word for word because I always assumed the important thing is to get the main points across and maybe recall a few quippy one-liners.
- The fact he had no car is insane to me...
- Also that teacher salary...
- Pretty interesting having the dichotomy of his peers and Rory(?)
- It's insane how all of these experiences occurred at basically my age (22-23) and I have to constantly remind myself of this fact
- I also think the accessibility of information has gotten way easier than it was back in his days so it's pretty fun seeing all the culture shock moments
- OMG I almost forgot about how many of his coworkers spoke English in the English department. There were like 3 fluent speakers and one loves talking about the Beatles or something. Another one went to Canada for study abroad iirc
- Wait there was also that like elderly English speaking thing he did
- Plus the introduction of his locked in arc (studying an hour before work every day is INSANE to me)
- Bullying 🌹
- Really funny how he talks about convenience stores booming his health because it fits my narrative that Japan does NOT make you skinnier
- Also lowkey crazy how his coworkers would just hit him with the "maybe u should relax on the fried chicken"
- The fact that coworkers would hide when they went on vacation is pretty funny but then you realize they're expected to bring back souvenirs for EVERYONE which is fried
- W Osaka trip. W rizz. L xenophobia
- Awesome seeing how locking in paid off by both winning the Japanese speech competition and finding a community he can feel comfortable around
- I lowkey forgot he had a girlfriend until writing this
- Natsuki W. Actually insane how he randomly meets these people but I guess that's just life. Also really funny how there's just a random ahh kitchen they go to LMFAO
 - This is also around when he first started going viral in Japan with his friends all swearing in English
 - Also where the weird white knight folks started appearing LMFAO

- I think it's also interesting seeing his thoughts on the English curriculum change over time as he started understanding how things operated. From the initial enthusiasm at the thought of overhauling it to an eventual acceptance that it's beyond systemic - the issue is at a fundamental level thanks to Confucius.
- Honestly I don't know much about Ryotoro except that Chris Broad mentions him a LOT in podcasts
- From what I've read it sounds like the random Youtube videos helped build an initial brand for Chris Broad and it's how he slowly started getting more opportunities
- Eventually he decided to just gamble and move to Sendai with like no savings 🤖
- The Australian crew working with him is also crazy even though he likely got super underpaid lol
- While short in a temporal sense I do want to highlight it because it really does go to show that everyone makes different life choices. Anyone who knows me can probably guess what my thoughts are on this transitional period LOL
- This is likely where MOST Youtuber autobiographies would start but I'm glad most of the book covers his life before this point since it gives an incredible sense of progress as an educator, Youtuber, and human-er...
- Accidental ICBM warning and going so viral he went to that crazy large talk show with Natsuki I think? Maybe Ryotoro
- Documentary on Fukushima nuclear disaster
- Meeting the GOAT (I lowkey forgot his name LOL)
- The Abroad in Japan series and how much burnout sucks